

Secure your mobile

When you buy that next great smartphone or a much-awaited tablet, don't hesitate to install a security app on it

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If The need to secure something personal and important to us is a natural instinct. Yet that instinct doesn't naturally extend over to a device that's increasingly becoming the centre of our attention: the smartphone. A general lack of awareness and an attitude confined to the PC era is to blame.

For better or worse, smartphones are increasingly becoming a part of our extended digital life. Along with this increased proliferation comes increased risk of exposing them to unforeseen vulnerabilities. In fact, in this day and age, the minute you turn on your phone you're at risk -- same as the minute you connect your PC to the net, you've to be on your guard. And the risks of today aren't just content with wreaking havoc in your PC, they have ulterior motives of mining your personal and profes-

sional data. As that data moves on to our smartphones and tablets, the bad guys wasting no time to follow us there.

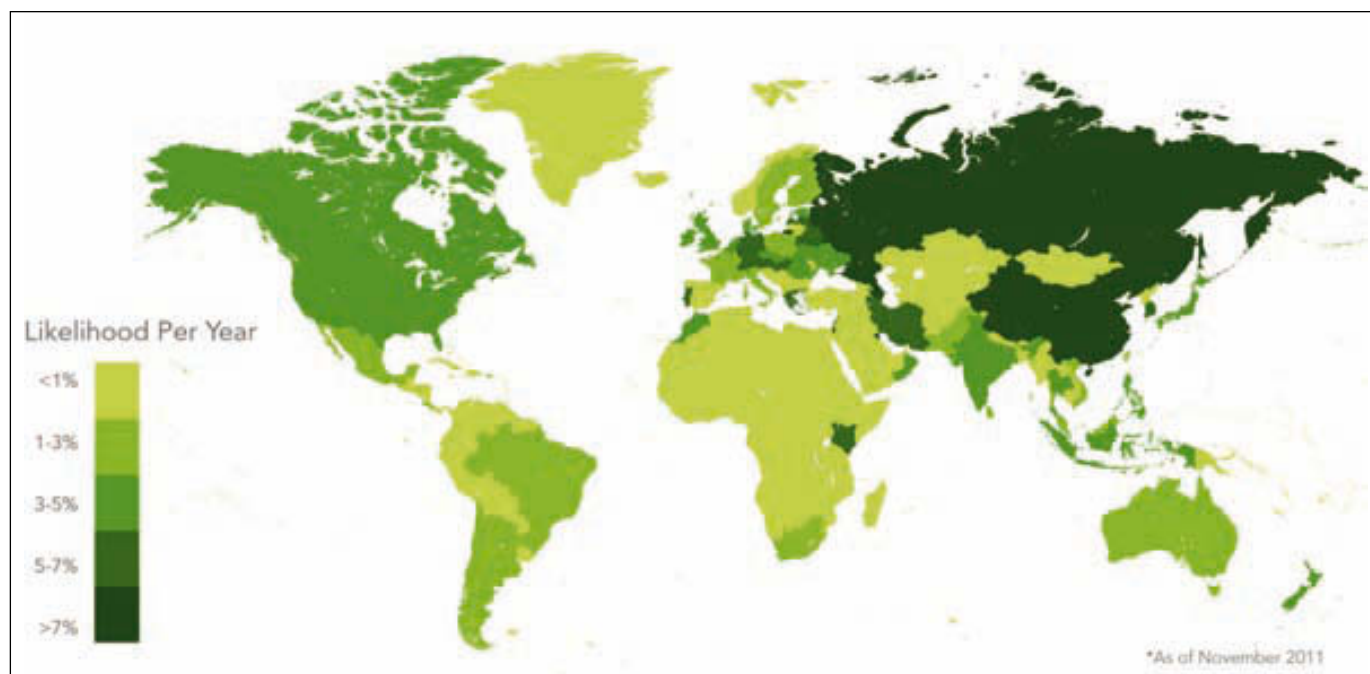
Why?

There are a multitude of threat reports, released over the past year or so, that point at a rising trend of malware infection on mobile platforms. Even from a malware architect's perspective, there is greater incentive in targeting smartphones and tablets because of two reasons: a) More people today are buying smartphones and tablets today than PCs or laptops; and b) Not many of them think of securing these devices with any anti-virus or anti-malware software. It's a no-brainer for the guys producing malware, and the perceived threat to handheld devices is quite real.

Android, the fastest growing mobile OS in terms of market share, is the most targetted OS since mid-2011, according to a security report. Since 2009, the

number of malware targetted at Android has grown by a whopping 400%. What's more, since Google doesn't police and screen the apps added into the Android Market, you (and Google) have no way of knowing whether that cool, new app with multiple recommendations is infected with a trojan or not. Chances are that unless you suspect fishy behaviour and report the app for Google to check, the malware app will just fly under the radar and continue to exist as a legitimate download option on the Market. Other mobile OSes may be lesser at risk compared to Android, but they aren't 100% safe without security software. Sad but true.

But that's not it. Anti-virus is one thing, but protecting your sensitive work and home-related data on your smartphone and tablet should be prime among the reasons why you should install a security app on your handheld device. For people who scatter



Annual Mobile Malware Infection Likelihood 2011